

SEASON ONE — EPISODE GUIDE

Episode 1 — “Mulberry Township”

The season opens in Johnson County, Arkansas, where the Civil War is not an abstract national conflict but a pressure moving through roads, houses, names, and kinship lines. In the past, the Horner household is introduced before violence enters it fully: family, land, work, rumor, allegiance, and warning signs. In the present, Daniel Bret Lingar opens the first layer of the archive and begins to understand that this story will not behave like a clean genealogy project. The episode establishes the central question: what happens when war reaches a house before history knows how to write it down?

Episode 2 — “The Chicken Dinner”

The violence moves closer. A household meal becomes the stage where ordinary family life and local war begin to occupy the same room. The episode tightens the world around the Horners, showing how gossip, suspicion, kinship, and road knowledge can become lethal in a guerrilla county. In the present, Daniel begins separating family tradition from documented fact, discovering that the emotional power of a story does not make it safe to repeat as proof. The episode ends with the sense that the family is no longer waiting for history. History has found the door.

Episode 3 — “The Cave”

After the attack, William Riley Horner survives long enough to become the moral center of the season. Hidden in a cave or overhang, cared for by the women of the family, he is kept alive through water, food, cloth, silence, and risk. Mary Ann and Permelia carry supplies disguised as baby bundles. John Samuel and Christopher are forced into adult vigilance before childhood has released them. In the present, Daniel learns that the cave is not a mystery location only; it is a witness. The episode ends not with rescue, but endurance: “We already are.”

Episode 4 — “The Refugee Train”

William Riley dies, but the family cannot stop moving. The episode follows the road out: displacement, refugee movement, damaged records, and the attempt to carry a death correctly while staying alive. The phrase “stayed” becomes a family counter-record against the flatness of official language. A roster, a road, and a child’s dirt drawing become early versions of the archive Daniel will later build. In the present, Daniel begins to see that the hardest part is not finding the road. It is refusing to pretend the line on the map is the whole truth.

Episode 5 — “Company K”

The family’s private loss reaches the military record. Company K becomes the table where names, deaths, sickness, rumor, and responsibility are sorted imperfectly but seriously. Dr. John Turner Horner’s central discipline emerges: ask before claiming, write before hunting, and do not let grief become certainty. The cluster of deaths around Company K gives the season its larger shape, but the episode refuses to turn proximity into proof. In the present, Daniel inherits the same rule: together is where questions start, not where proof ends.

Episode 6 — “Wash Middleton”

The season enters the most dangerous territory: the space between maybe and action. Wash Middleton and Fate Arnold move through the reprisal layer of the story, where anger wants a target and rumor wants a gun. Outside a lit house, with civilians inside and evidence insufficient, Wash holds the line. No shot is fired. No action taken. Returned to table. In the present, Daniel confronts the temptation to make characters larger, cleaner, or more useful than the evidence allows. The episode's power comes from restraint: sometimes the most important thing history never records is what did not happen.

Episode 7 — “The Marriage”

John Samuel Acord marries Amanda Catherine Hill, but the episode refuses to treat the marriage as healing, absolution, or symbolic peace. Amanda enters with a name the county reads too quickly, and she corrects the room before the ledger can collapse her into it: if they mean John Fry Hill, say John Fry Hill; if they mean Joseph Hill's house, say Joseph Hill's house. The resisted bread scene at the table makes refusal visible before crossing can mean anything. The marriage does not close the wound. It makes a table where the wound can no longer be the only thing in the room.

Episode 8 — “The Inheritance”

The finale brings the season's method into Daniel's hands. Two files, two roads: a clean revenge version that would sell, and a disciplined account that refuses to lie. Daniel deletes the revenge cut. He takes his four children — Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, and Adalee — to Moore Cemetery at dusk, builds a tailgate table from the objects of the season, and teaches them what the story has taught him: do not let pain make you lazy with the truth. The story-fire opens. The dead speak the sentences the records could not hold. The children draw the road again in the dirt, adding the table, the gate, the loop, and the line forward. The season ends with inheritance transformed from wound into instruction.